

63 Goliath

The giant of Gath who defied the armies of the living God, and fell to a shepherd's sling.

Goliath was the Philistine champion from Gath. A giant in heavy bronze armor, for forty days he dared Israel to send someone to fight him, and Saul's soldiers were terrified. Then David, a young shepherd bringing food to his brothers, heard the challenge and saw it differently. To him Goliath was not first a giant but a man who had defied the living God. Nearly all we know of Goliath is his size, his weapons and his boasting. In Scripture his fall shows what God can do through someone who trusts him.

At a glance

Name	Goliath. The meaning of the name is uncertain
From	Gath, one of the five chief Philistine cities (1 Samuel 17:4)
Height	"Six cubits and a span," about 9 ft 9 in; some copies read four (17:4)
Weapons	Bronze armor; a spear "like a weaver's beam" (1 Samuel 17:5–7)
Key place	The valley of Elah (1 Samuel 17:1–2)
Key people	David, Saul, Goliath's shield-bearer
New Testament	Not named

"Then said David to the Philistine, Thou comest to me with a sword, and with a spear, and with a shield: but I come to thee in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom thou hast defied."

1 Samuel 17:45, KJV

The life of Goliath

Scripture gives no dates or ages for Goliath. The battle took place in Saul's reign (c. 1050–1010 BC), while David was still a youth.

Before the battle	● Champion of the Philistines Goliath of Gath stands out as the Philistine champion. He is covered in bronze, his spearhead alone weighs six hundred shekels of iron, and a shield-bearer walks in front of him. <i>1 Samuel 17:4–7</i>
Forty days	● Defies Israel Morning and evening he calls across the valley: "choose you a man for you," and the loser's people will serve the winner's. Saul and all Israel are dismayed and greatly afraid. <i>1 Samuel 17:8–11, 16</i>
The fortieth day	● Meets a shepherd David arrives with food for his brothers and hears the challenge. When Goliath sees him coming with a staff and a sling, he despises him as a mere youth and curses him by his gods. <i>1 Samuel 17:20–44</i>
That day	● Falls in the valley David slings a single stone, which sinks into Goliath's forehead. He falls on his face, and David kills him with his own sword. The Philistines flee, and Israel chases them to Gath and Ekron. <i>1 Samuel 17:48–53</i>
Afterwards	● His sword is kept David takes Goliath's head to Jerusalem and his armor to his tent. Later his sword is kept wrapped in a cloth at Nob, and the priest gives it to David. <i>1 Samuel 17:54; 21:8–9</i>

Group notes

Key activities

1 Samuel 17:4 in the standard Hebrew text gives Goliath's height as six cubits and a span. The Dead Sea Scrolls copy of Samuel, the Greek Septuagint and the historian Josephus give four cubits and a span, about 6 feet 9 inches (about 2 meters). Either way, he was far taller than the men around him.

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- 1 **Boasted in his armor.** He trusted his bronze armor, his great spear and his shield-bearer. *1 Samuel 17:5-7*
 - 2 **Defied Israel for forty days.** He cried, "I defy the armies of Israel this day; give me a man, that we may fight together." *1 Samuel 17:10, 16*
 - 3 **Paralyzed an army with fear.** When the men of Israel saw him, they fled and were sore afraid. *1 Samuel 17:11, 24*
 - 4 **Despised the youth sent against him.** He asked, "Am I a dog, that thou comest to me with staves?" and cursed David by his gods. *1 Samuel 17:42-43*
 - 5 **Threatened to feed David to the birds.** He promised to give David's flesh "unto the fowls of the air, and to the beasts of the field." *1 Samuel 17:44*
 - 6 **Fell to one stone.** He fell on his face, and David, who had no sword in his hand, used Goliath's own. *1 Samuel 17:49-51*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Goliath.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 17	The main account
1 Samuel 21:9; 22:10	His sword kept at Nob and given to David
2 Samuel 21:19; 1 Chronicles 20:5	Elhanan and "the brother of Goliath"; copying debated
2 Samuel 21:15–22	David's men kill four other giants of Gath
Echo: Numbers 13:33	The spies felt like grasshoppers before giants
Echo: Psalm 20:7	"Some trust in chariots, and some in horses"

New Testament

Echo: 1 Corinthians 1:27	God chooses the weak to confound the mighty
Echo: Colossians 2:15	Christ "spoiled principalities and powers"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How is Goliath's armor described, and why so much detail (1 Samuel 17:4–7)?
2. *Understand:* David called Goliath one who "defied the armies of the living God" (1 Samuel 17:26, 36). How did that change the way he saw the fight?
3. *Apply:* Israel listened to Goliath's threats for forty days. What fear has been shouting at you for a long time?
4. *Apply:* David used the tools he had practiced with as a shepherd. What ordinary skill or experience might God use in the challenge in front of you?